

MAKI Tagging — Quick Guide

Each tag answers a distinct question about the photo. Carry one from each facet; intersect in search.

Principles rules that keep the tag catalogue coherent over years

- 1. Tag in hierarchies.** Separator is |. Ancestors auto-expand: `subject|nature|landscape` also stores `subject|nature` and `subject`.
- 2. Generic lowercase, proper nouns keep case.** `concert` not `Concert`; `Peter Schneider` stays capitalised; `Germany` in English but `München` local.
- 3. One language.** Pick one and stick with it. Place names: English for countries, local from region down.
- 4. Facets are orthogonal.** Independent axes, not nested. Intersect in queries; don't mash into one tree.
- 5. Tag what you see.** Primary tags describe visible content; context goes in secondary tags.
- 6. Don't duplicate metadata.** Camera, lens, date, GPS are EXIF; folders are path. Don't tag them.
- 7. Aim for 5–15 tags per image.** Fewer is poor discoverability; more is usually noise.
- 8. Separate workflow from content.** Ratings / color labels / saved searches for state. Tags for content.

The Facets one question per axis — any photo can carry a tag from each

What is in the image?

`subject|nature|landscape`
`subject|animal|bird`
`subject|urban|architecture`
`subject|person|portrait`
`subject|performing arts|concert`
`subject|event|wedding`
`subject|object|food`
`subject|mood|dramatic`

Which specific occasion?

`event|wedding-jane-2025`
`event|fuji-trip-2023`
`event|workshop-la-2019`

Date-driven, grows unboundedly. Flat naming or `event|2025|...`. Separate from `subject|event|*`, which is the generic scene type.

Where was it taken?

`location|Germany`
`location|Germany|Bayern`
`location|Germany|Bayern|München`
`location|Germany|Bayern|Geltling|Kulturbühne Hinterhalt`

Countries in English; local names from region down.

Who is in it?

`person|family`
`person|friend|Alice Müller`
`person|artist|musician|Peter Schneider`
`person|ensemble|band|Alice Viola Trio`

For large catalogues, consider face recognition instead of manual person tags.

How was it made?

`technique|style|black and white`
`technique|lighting|golden hour`
`technique|lighting|stage lighting`
`technique|exposure|long exposure`
`technique|composition|symmetry`
`technique|effect|bokeh`

Which project/assignment?

`project|365 pictures 2018`
`project|Bricking Bavaria`
`project|Workshop LA 2019`

Purely personal. Names are proper nouns; keep original case.

Dominant content colour?

`color|red` `color|blue`
`color|warm` `color|cold`
`color|monochrome`
`color|pastel` `color|muted`

Keep flat. Content colour is different from MAKI's editorial color-label field (5 fixed values).

Ask: what distinct question does this answer?

- New question → **top-level facet**.
- Refines an existing axis → **nest it**.
- Date-driven instance (weddings, trips) → top-level.
- Visual property (colour, tone) → top-level.
- Nameable & scoped (projects) → top-level.

Facets are cheap to add; wrong nesting is expensive to fix later.

One photo, many facets a photo from Jane's 2025 wedding reception

A single photo can intersect every facet. Each tag answers a different question about the same image:

`subject|event|wedding`
`subject|person|group`
`subject|mood|joyful`
`event|wedding-jane-2025`
`location|Germany|Bayern|München`
`person|friend|Alice M.`
`technique|lighting|golden hour`
`technique|style|documentary`
`color|warm`

scene type
composition
mood
specific occasion
where
who
how lit
how shot
dominant colour

9 leaf tags across 7 facets. With ancestor expansion, ~15 tags stored. Search `"event:wedding-jane-2025 person:Alice color:warm"` intersects three orthogonal axes.

Three places for event-related tags

three different questions, three different tags — they coexist on the same photo

`subject|performing arts|concert`
`subject|event|wedding`
`event|wedding-jane-2025`

photo depicts a performance
photo depicts a ceremony / gathering
photo is from this specific occasion

A wedding photo can carry both `subject|event|wedding` and `event|wedding-jane-2025`. A concert photo fits under `subject|performing arts|concert`, not `subject|event|*`.

Tag commands CLI and web UI share the same operations and the same semantics

<code>maki tag ID foo bar</code>	Add tags (ancestors auto-expanded).
<code>maki tag ID --remove foo</code>	Remove tags (orphaned ancestors cleaned).
<code>maki tag clear ID</code>	Remove all tags from an asset.
<code>maki tag rename OLD NEW --apply</code>	Rename a tag everywhere. Cascades to descendants.
<code>maki tag delete TAG --apply</code>	Delete a tag (and descendants) from every asset.
<code>maki tag split OLD A B... --apply</code>	Replace one tag with multiple (variadic).
<code>... --keep</code>	Keep source alongside (additive / copy).
<code>maki tag expand-ancestors --apply</code>	Backfill ancestor paths on existing tags.
<code>maki tag fix-unicode --apply</code>	NFC-normalise tag values; merges NFC/NFD duplicates.
<code>maki tag export-vocabulary</code>	Export the tag tree as <code>vocabulary.yaml</code> .
<code>... --default</code>	Export the built-in starter vocabulary (ignores catalogue).
<code>... --format text</code>	Tab-indented file for Lightroom / Capture One keyword import.
<code>... --format json</code>	Nested-object JSON with per-tag asset counts (for scripts).
<code>... --counts</code>	In YAML, append <code># N assets</code> trailing comments.

<code>tag:landscape</code>	Tag match at any level (default).
<code>tag=:landscape</code>	Whole-path match (exact tag value).
<code>tag:/landscape</code>	Leaf only at any level.
<code>tag:^Landscape</code>	Case-sensitive.
<code>tag: wed</code>	Prefix anchor (wedding, wedding-...).
<code>-tag:rejected</code>	Exclude.
<code>tag:a,b</code>	Either a or b.
<code>tag:a tag:b</code>	Both a and b.
<code>event:jane person:Alice color:warm</code>	Intersect three facets.

Same filters work in CLI `maki search` and in the web UI search box.

